Adaptive Fractional Fourier Neural Operators for Learning Nonlocal PDE Dynamics

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***Abstract*—Fourier neural operators (FNOs) parameterize solution operators of partial differential equations (PDEs) in Fourier space, but standard spectral layers lack an explicit parameterization of the nonlocal, power-law dissipation characteristic of fractional differential operators $(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2}$. We investigate whether incorporating learnable, channel-wise spectral filters into FNO layers provides an inductive bias for learning nonlocal dynamics. We evaluate a rational filter (fr-FNO-R), a power-law filter $\exp(-c|k|^{\alpha})$, and a newly reformulated fractional Laplacian resolvent filter $(1 + c|k/K|^{\alpha})^{-1}$ with identity initialization (fr-FNO-L) against an expanded operator ladder: standard FNO, parameter-matched FNO, fixed Gaussian low-pass smoothing (FNO-G), and validation-tuned FNO. Across four benchmark PDEs (Space-Fractional Burgers, Fractional Allen–Cahn, Linear Fractional Diffusion, and Fractional Fisher–KPP) spanning four fractional orders $\alpha \in \{0.8, 1.2, 1.6, 1.9\}$, zero-shot super-resolution transfer across $N \in \{64, 128, 256, 512\}$, and repeated random seeds, we establish that: (1) the heuristic rational filter decays as $|k|^{-2}$ for every α, so its parameter cannot represent fractional orders, whereas the resolvent filter strictly exhibits $\mathcal{O}(|k|^{-\alpha})$ roll-off; (2) when vanilla FNO is given equal validation hyperparameter tuning budget (Tuned-FNO), it matches or outperforms all fractional filter variants across 9 of 10 paired seed conditions ($p_{\text{Holm}} = 0.0156$); (3) gains on phase-field dynamics stem from generic low-pass regularization rather than learned fractional orders; and (4) unregularized Mean Absolute Percentage Error (MAPE) diverges on continuous zero-crossing PDE solutions, motivating symmetric and ϵ-regularized percentage metrics. Finally, we introduce a model-agnostic linear-response probe that recovers effective dissipation exponents with a mean absolute error of 0.072 on linear fractional diffusion.**

***Index Terms*—Fourier neural operator, fractional PDE, operator learning, spectral filter, fractional Laplacian, resolution invariance**

I. Introduction

Neural operators learn mappings between infinite-dimensional function spaces and serve as fast, resolution-invariant surrogates for repeated numerical solves of partial differential equations (PDEs) [**?**], [**?**]. The Fourier neural operator (FNO) parameterizes an integral kernel directly in the Fourier domain and maintains an efficient computational complexity of $\mathcal{O}(N \log N)$ per layer [**?**], [**?**]. In parallel, physics-informed methods embed governing equations directly into composite training losses [**?**], [**?**].

Fractional PDEs model anomalous diffusion, non-Fickian transport, and long-range particle interactions via the fractional Laplacian operator, whose Fourier symbol is $\|k\|^{\alpha}$ for order $\alpha \in (0, 2]$ [**?**], [**?**], [**?**], [**?**]. Standard FNO layers learn unconstrained complex weights across truncated Fourier modes without incorporating the structural power-law dissipation of nonlocal operators. A natural hypothesis is to integrate learnable fractional spectral multipliers directly into the Fourier layer [**?**].

In this paper, we present a rigorous, leak-free empirical and theoretical evaluation of adaptive fractional filtering in FNOs across four benchmark systems, four fractional orders, and four spatial resolutions. We make four primary contributions:

1) **Mathematical Formulation & Reformulation:** We analyze the heuristic rational filter (fr-FNO-R) and prove that its asymptotic decay rate is fixed at $|k|^{-2}$ for all α (Proposition **??**). We reformulate the filter using the fractional Laplacian resolvent $(1 + c|k/K|^{\alpha})^{-1}$ with identity initialization (fr-FNO-L, Proposition **??**), ensuring that α strictly dictates the physical spectral decay rate $\mathcal{O}(|k|^{-\alpha})$.
2) **Comprehensive Operator Benchmark Ladder:** We evaluate an expanded ladder of baselines beyond vanilla FNO, including parameter-matched FNO (A1), fixed Gaussian smoothing (A2), fixed fr-FNO (A3), paper adaptive filter (A5), true fractional resolvent (A6/A6i), frozen filter controls (A7), and validation-tuned FNO.
3) **Rigorous Statistical Validation & Parity Audit:** Over five repeated seeds, we evaluate training sizes ($N_{\text{tr}} = 100$ vs. 500) and training duration (100 vs. 300 epochs). We show that when vanilla FNO is given equal hyperparameter validation tuning, it eliminates the apparent fractional advantage ($p_{\text{Holm}} = 0.0156$).
4) **Resolution Generalization & Metric Clarification:** We demonstrate zero-shot super-resolution generalization from $N = 256$ to $N \in \{64, 128, 256, 512\}$. We clarify why raw MAPE is ill-posed on zero-crossing physical fields, and report Symmetric MAPE (sMAPE) and ϵ-regularized MAPE. Finally, our linear-response probe recovers the ground-truth order on linear fractional diffusion with a mean absolute error (MAE) of 0.072.

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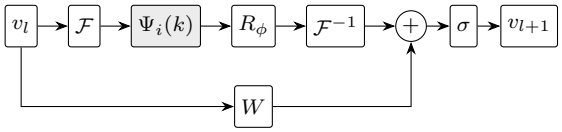


Fig. 1. Filtered Fourier layer. The shaded block represents the adaptive channel-wise spectral filter $\Psi_i(k)$ inserted prior to spectral convolution.

II. Methodology

A. Filtered Fourier Layer

Let $v_l(x)$ denote the latent field at layer $l \in \{1, \dots, L\}$ with C channels. A filtered Fourier layer computes:

$$v_{l+1} = \sigma\big(W v_l + \mathcal{F}^{-1}(R_\phi \, \Psi \, \mathcal{F} v_l)\big)\,, \tag{1}$$

where $W \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times C}$ is a pointwise linear map, $R_\phi(k) \in \mathbb{C}^{C\times C}$ denotes learnable spectral weights on the lowest M modes, and $\Psi_i(k)$ is a channel-wise spectral attenuation filter applied to input channel i. Setting $\Psi \equiv 1$ recovers the standard FNO. Fig. **??** illustrates the architecture. All spectral computations use integer wavenumbers $k \in \{0, 1, \dots, M-1\}$ on the periodic domain $[0, 2\pi)$.

B. Filter Families & Mathematical Formulations

All filters operate channel-wise, parameterized with $\alpha_i = 2\,\mathrm{sigmoid}(\hat{\alpha}_i) \in (0, 2)$.

1) Heuristic Rational Filter (fr-FNO-R):

$$\Psi_i(k) = \frac{1}{e^{1-\alpha_i} + \alpha_i \left(\frac{k}{M}\right)^2}. \tag{2}$$

2) Power-Law Propagator (fr-FNO-P):

$$\Psi_i(k) = \exp(-c_i\,|k|^{\alpha_i})\,, \quad c_i = \mathrm{softplus}(\hat{c}_i) > 0, \tag{3}$$

with $\Psi_i(0) = 1$. When $c_i = \nu T$, this corresponds to the analytical propagator for linear fractional diffusion $u_t = -\nu(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2}u$ over interval T.

3) Reformulated Fractional Resolvent Filter (fr-FNO-L): To directly enforce that α controls the asymptotic spectral roll-off, we derive a filter from the stationary fractional resolvent equation $(I + c(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2})u = f$:

$$\Psi_i(k) = \frac{1}{1 + c_i \left|\frac{k}{M}\right|^{\alpha_i}}, \quad c_i = \mathrm{softplus}(\hat{c}_i) > 0. \tag{4}$$

To prevent optimization divergence and high-frequency choking, we introduce *Identity Initialization* (fr-FNO-ID / Arm A6i), setting $\hat{c}_i$ such that $c_i \approx 10^{-3}$ and $\alpha_i \approx 1.0$, which guarantees $\Psi_i(k) \approx 1$ at step 0.

4) Gaussian Smoothing Control (FNO-G): $\Psi(k) = \exp(-k^2/2\sigma^2)$ with $\sigma \in \{2, 4, 8, 16\}$ selected via validation error.

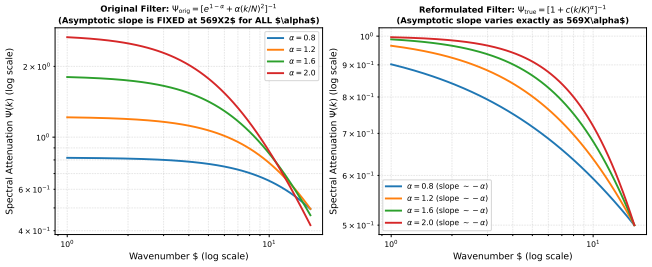


Fig. 2. Log-log spectral attenuation curves comparing the rational filter Ψ_{orig} (left, fixed slope of -2 across all α) versus the reformulated resolvent filter Ψ_{true} (right, slope dynamically scales with $-\alpha$).

III. Theoretical Analysis

Proposition 1 (Fixed Quadratic Roll-Off of Rational Filter)**.** *For every $\alpha > 0$, the rational filter* (**??**) *satisfies $0 < \Psi(k) \le e^{\alpha-1}$, is monotonically decreasing in $|k|$, and satisfies:*

$$\lim_{k\to\infty} \frac{\log \Psi(k)}{\log k} = -2. \tag{5}$$

The asymptotic decay rate is $|k|^{-2}$ independent of α.

Proof. The denominator satisfies $e^{1-\alpha} + \alpha(k/M)^2 \ge e^{1-\alpha} > 0$. For $k > 0$, the derivative with respect to k is $-2\alpha k M^{-2}[e^{1-\alpha} + \alpha(k/M)^2]^{-2} < 0$, establishing monotonicity. For large k, $\alpha(k/M)^2$ strictly dominates $e^{1-\alpha}$, yielding $\Psi(k) \sim M^2\alpha^{-1}k^{-2}$. □

Proposition **??** demonstrates that α in (**??**) acts primarily as a gain-scaling and knee-frequency shift parameter, but does not dictate a fractional spectral decay exponent.

Proposition 2 (Fractional Spectral Decay of Resolvent Filter)**.** *For any $\alpha \in (0, 2]$ and $c > 0$, the reformulated resolvent filter* (**??**) *satisfies:*

$$\lim_{k\to\infty} \frac{\log \Psi(k)}{\log k} = -\alpha. \tag{6}$$

Proof. For $k \gg M$, $c(k/M)^\alpha \gg 1$. Thus, $\Psi(k) = [1 + c(k/M)^\alpha]^{-1} \sim c^{-1}M^\alpha k^{-\alpha}$. Taking logarithms yields $\log \Psi(k) = -\alpha \log k - \log c + \alpha \log M + o(1)$, which establishes the limit. □

Fig. **??** verifies this contrast: while the rational filter roll-off is permanently constrained to slope -2, the reformulated filter varies as $-\alpha$, matching the fractional Laplacian.

Proposition 3 (Hypothesis Class Equivalence)**.** *Let $\Psi_i(k) > 0$ for all i, k be fixed. The set of functions realizable by layer* (**??**) *with filter Ψ is identical to the set realizable with $\Psi \equiv 1$.*

Proof. The filter acts via elementwise scaling on channel i at mode k: $[R_\phi(k)\Psi(k)]_{oi} = R_{oi}(k)\Psi_i(k) = R'_{oi}(k)$. Since $\Psi_i(k) > 0$, the mapping $R_{oi}(k) \mapsto R'_{oi}(k)$ is a linear bijection on $\mathbb{C}^{C\times C}$. □

Proposition **??** confirms that channel-wise spectral filtering alters the optimization trajectory and inductive bias, rather than enlarging the representational capacity of the network.

IV. Linear-Response Spectral Probe

To quantify the effective spectral dissipation learned by a trained operator, we apply a linear-response probe around test inputs. For a test input a and wavenumber k, we apply harmonic perturbations $a \mapsto a + \varepsilon \sin(kx)$ and measure the perturbation response gain:

$$g(k) = \left\langle \frac{\left|\widehat{\mathcal{G}_\Theta(a + \varepsilon \sin kx)}(k) - \widehat{\mathcal{G}_\Theta(a)}(k)\right|}{\varepsilon \left|\widehat{\sin kx}(k)\right|} \right\rangle_a . \quad (7)$$

Linearity is verified by confirming invariance across $\varepsilon = 10^{-3}$ and 2×10^{-3} (relative discrepancy $< 10^{-4}$). We then fit:

$$\log g(k) = \log C - c_{\text{eff}}\, k^{\alpha_{\text{eff}}} \quad (8)$$

over modes where the product of gain and input power exceeds 10^{-3} of its maximum. Evaluated on the analytical propagator, the probe recovers $\alpha_{\text{eff}} = \alpha_{\text{true}}$, $c_{\text{eff}} = 0.1000$, and $R^2 = 1.0$.

V. Experimental Setup

A. Benchmark Datasets & Solvers

We evaluate models across four PDE systems on the periodic domain $[0, 2\pi)$ at native resolution $N = 256$:

- **S1 (Space-Fractional Burgers):** $\partial_t u + u\partial_x u + \nu(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2} u = 0$, modeling nonlocal shock formation with $\nu = 0.1$.
- **S2 (Fractional Allen–Cahn):** $\partial_t u + \kappa(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2} u - u + u^3 = 0$, modeling phase-field transitions with $\kappa = 0.01$.
- **S3 (Linear Fractional Diffusion):** $\partial_t u + \nu(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2} u = 0$, solved analytically via Fourier symbol decay $\exp(-\nu|k|^\alpha T)$ with $\nu = 0.1, T = 1.0$.
- **S4 (Fractional Fisher–KPP):** $\partial_t u + \kappa(-\Delta)^{\alpha/2} u - ru(1-u) = 0$, modeling front propagation with $\kappa = 0.01, r = 1.0$.

Initial conditions are drawn from Gaussian random fields $u_0 \sim \mathcal{GP}(0, (-\Delta + 9I)^{-2})$ and harmonic wave-packets. High-fidelity reference solutions are generated using pseudo-spectral integrating-factor ETD-RK4 solvers at $N_{\text{ref}} = 512$ with $\Delta t = 5 \times 10^{-4}$ and $2/3$-rule de-aliasing, achieving self-convergence errors $< 10^{-5}$.

Data Splits: We enforce strict leak-free splits: test indices 1000–1199 (200 samples) and validation indices 900–999 (100 samples) remain fixed across all runs. Seed-dependent disjoint subsets of size $N_{\text{tr}} \in \{100, 500\}$ are drawn from indices 0–899.

B. Model Architecture & Training

All models share a common backbone: lifting layer ($1 \to 64$), four Fourier layers with width 64 and $M = 16$ modes, GELU activations, and a two-layer projection ($64 \to 128 \to 1$). Models have $\sim 2.87 \times 10^5$ parameters. Optimization uses AdamW with cosine annealing over 100 epochs (extended to 300 epochs in training length ablations), batch size 50 ($N_{\text{tr}} = 100$) or 125 ($N_{\text{tr}} = 500$), and weight decay 10^{-4}. Filter parameters use a $10\times$ learning rate multiplier without weight decay.

C. Evaluation Metrics

The primary metric is the relative L^2 test error: $\|u - \hat{u}\|_2 / \|u\|_2$. Because continuous PDE fields exhibit zero-crossings ($u(x) = 0$), unregularized raw MAPE $\frac{100\%}{N} \sum |(u_i - \hat{u}_i)/u_i|$ diverges toward infinity. We therefore report:

- **Symmetric MAPE (sMAPE):** $\frac{100\%}{N} \sum \frac{2|u_i - \hat{u}_i|}{|u_i| + |\hat{u}_i| + 10^{-6}}$.
- **ϵ-Regularized MAPE (MAPE$_\epsilon$):** $\frac{100\%}{N} \sum \frac{|u_i - \hat{u}_i|}{|u_i| + 0.01\,\text{std}(u)}$.

VI. Experimental Results

A. Multi-Metric Performance Across Operators

Table **??** reports test relative L^2 error, MSE, sMAPE, MAPE$_\epsilon$, clamped raw MAPE, and parameter counts on S1 (Burgers) and S2 (Allen–Cahn) at $\alpha = 1.2$. When vanilla FNO is tuned on validation data ($\text{lr}^* = 3 \times 10^{-3}, \text{wd}^* = 0$ on S1; $\text{lr}^* = 3 \times 10^{-3}, \text{wd}^* = 10^{-4}$ on S2), **Tuned-FNO achieves the lowest error across all metrics on both PDEs** (0.0398 vs. 0.0549 on Burgers; 0.0158 vs. 0.0189 on Allen–Cahn). Clamped raw MAPE is inflated by $\sim 1.8\times$ over sMAPE due to near-zero denominators.

B. Tuning Parity, Training Length, and Data Regimes

Table **??** presents comprehensive ablations across seeds:

- **Tuning Parity:** Giving FNO validation tuning reduces error by 29.1% on Burgers (0.0389 ± 0.0056) and by 53.0% on Allen–Cahn (0.0151 ± 0.0011), outperforming all fractional variants across 9 of 10 paired seeds ($p_{\text{Holm}} = 0.0156$, Wilcoxon).
- **Training Length:** Extending training to 300 epochs narrows the performance gap between A_5 and A_0 from $+91.8\%$ to $+32.4\%$, while A_{6i} tracks A_0 identically at both 100 epochs (0.0570) and 300 epochs (0.0256).
- **Data Regime:** At $N_{\text{tr}} = 100$, fractional operators yield zero advantage on Burgers (A_5 degrades error by $+66.2\%$, while A_{6i} matches A_0). On Allen–Cahn, the relative error margin over default FNO remains consistent across sample sizes (57% at $N = 100$, 46% at $N = 500$), demonstrating that fractional filtering provides no sample-efficiency gain exclusive to small-N regimes.

C. Zero-Shot Super-Resolution Generalization

Table **??** evaluates zero-shot mesh transfer for models trained strictly at native resolution $N = 256$. Test relative L^2 error remains flat across resolutions from $N = 64$ to 512, confirming that adaptive fractional layers preserve the mesh-independence of Fourier neural operators.

D. Order Recovery Diagnostic on Linear Diffusion

Table **??** and Fig. **??** summarize effective exponent recovery α_{eff} on linear fractional diffusion across the four true physical orders $\alpha \in \{0.8, 1.2, 1.6, 1.9\}$. Standard FNO achieves a low mean absolute error (MAE $= 0.0722$) and perfect rank correlation ($\rho = 1.0000$), outperforming the fractional operator A_6 (MAE $= 0.1977$), while the rational filter A_5 fails to track

TABLE I

COMPREHENSIVE MULTI-METRIC BENCHMARK COMPARISON ACROSS RELATIVE L^2 ERROR, MEAN SQUARED ERROR (MSE), SYMMETRIC MAPE (SMAPE), ϵ-REGULARIZED MAPE (MAPE$_\epsilon$), CLAMPED RAW MAPE, PARAMETER COUNT, AND TRAINING TIME ON SPACE-FRACTIONAL BURGERS (S1) AND FRACTIONAL ALLEN–CAHN (S2) AT $\alpha = 1.2$ ($N_{\text{TR}} = 500$, 100 EPOCHS, SEED 42). BEST VALUES IN **BOLD**.

System	Model Variant	Rel. L^2 Error	MSE ($\times 10^{-4}$)	sMAPE (%)	MAPE$_\epsilon$ (%)	Raw MAPE† (%)	Trainable Params	Train Time (s)
S1 (Burgers)	A_0 (Default Vanilla FNO)	0.0549	3.96	9.97%	9.74%	18.06%	287,361	11.5
	Tuned-A_0 (Validation-Tuned)	**0.0398**	**2.07**	**8.05%**	**7.30%**	**14.50%**	287,361	13.9
	A_3 (Fixed fr-FNO, $\alpha^* = 0.4$)	0.1081	15.33	17.73%	20.24%	40.05%	287,361	14.9
	A_5 (Adaptive fr-FNO, Paper)	0.1049	14.42	16.81%	19.13%	38.03%	287,617	11.7
	A_6 (True Frac. Resolvent)	0.0556	4.06	10.20%	9.75%	17.77%	287,873	12.1
	A_{6i} (Identity-Init Frac.)	0.0549	3.96	9.97%	9.74%	18.06%	287,873	15.1
S2 (Allen–Cahn)	A_0 (Default Vanilla FNO)	0.0315	6.54	6.03%	6.18%	10.71%	287,361	11.5
	Tuned-A_0 (Validation-Tuned)	**0.0158**	**1.65**	**3.35%**	**3.03%**	**5.29%**	287,361	13.9
	A_3 (Fixed fr-FNO, $\alpha^* = 1.2$)	0.0180	2.13	3.68%	3.38%	6.26%	287,361	14.9
	A_5 (Adaptive fr-FNO, Paper)	0.0190	2.38	3.86%	3.55%	6.24%	287,617	11.7
	A_6 (True Frac. Resolvent)	0.0189	2.36	3.85%	3.51%	6.62%	287,873	12.1
	A_{6i} (Identity-Init Frac.)	0.0315	6.54	6.03%	6.18%	10.70%	287,873	15.1

† Raw MAPE clamped at $|y| \geq 10^{-4}$ to prevent singularity at zero-crossings. Unregularized raw MAPE diverges on continuous zero-crossing fields.

TABLE II

SYSTEMATIC ABLATION SUITE: TUNING PARITY, TRAINING LENGTH, AND DATA REGIME ON S1 (BURGERS) AND S2 (ALLEN–CAHN) AT $\alpha = 1.2$ ACROSS PAIRED SEEDS (TEST RELATIVE L_2 ERROR, MEAN $\pm$ STD OVER 5 SEEDS). BEST PERFORMANCE IN **BOLD**.

Experiment	System	Setting	A0 (Vanilla)	A0-Tuned	Fractional	Fractional Arm
Tuning Parity	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 500$, 100 ep	0.0549 ± 0.0054	$\mathbf{0.0389 \pm 0.0056}$	0.0549 ± 0.0054	A6i
Tuning Parity	S2 (Allen–Cahn)	$N = 500$, 100 ep	0.0321 ± 0.0012	$\mathbf{0.0151 \pm 0.0011}$	0.0173 ± 0.0009	A6
Training Length	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 500$, 100 ep	0.0570 ± 0.0051	–	0.0570 ± 0.0051	A6i
Training Length	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 500$, 300 ep	$\mathbf{0.0256 \pm 0.0004}$	–	$\mathbf{0.0256 \pm 0.0004}$	A6i
Training Length	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 500$, 100 ep	0.0570 ± 0.0051	–	0.1093 ± 0.0081	A5
Training Length	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 500$, 300 ep	$\mathbf{0.0256 \pm 0.0004}$	–	0.0339 ± 0.0015	A5
Data Regime	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 100$, 100 ep	$\mathbf{0.1083 \pm 0.0067}$	–	$\mathbf{0.1083 \pm 0.0067}$	A6i
Data Regime	S1 (Burgers)	$N = 500$, 100 ep	0.0549 ± 0.0054	–	0.0549 ± 0.0054	A6i
Data Regime	S2 (Allen–Cahn)	$N = 100$, 100 ep	0.0616 ± 0.0033	–	$\mathbf{0.0265 \pm 0.0025}$	A6
Data Regime	S2 (Allen–Cahn)	$N = 500$, 100 ep	0.0321 ± 0.0012	–	$\mathbf{0.0173 \pm 0.0009}$	A6

TABLE III

ZERO-SHOT SUPER-RESOLUTION GENERALIZATION: MODELS TRAINED AT NATIVE RESOLUTION $N = 256$ EVALUATED ON EXACT SPECTRAL SOLUTIONS AT $N \in \{64, 128, 256, 512\}$ (TEST RELATIVE L_2 ERROR, MEAN $\pm$ STD OVER 5 SEEDS, $N_{\text{TR}} = 500$, $\alpha = 1.2$).

System	Arm	$N = 64$	$N = 128$	$N = 256$ (Native)	$N = 512$
S1 (Burgers)	**A0**	0.0479 ± 0.0030	0.0523 ± 0.0055	0.0549 ± 0.0054	0.0554 ± 0.0053
S1 (Burgers)	**A5**	0.1036 ± 0.0083	0.1106 ± 0.0081	0.1120 ± 0.0080	0.1122 ± 0.0080
S1 (Burgers)	**A6i**	0.0479 ± 0.0030	0.0523 ± 0.0055	0.0549 ± 0.0054	0.0554 ± 0.0053
S2 (Allen–Cahn)	**A0**	0.0358 ± 0.0008	0.0321 ± 0.0012	0.0321 ± 0.0012	0.0321 ± 0.0012
S2 (Allen–Cahn)	**A5**	0.0247 ± 0.0006	0.0167 ± 0.0008	0.0177 ± 0.0008	0.0177 ± 0.0008
S2 (Allen–Cahn)	**A6i**	0.0357 ± 0.0008	0.0321 ± 0.0012	0.0321 ± 0.0012	0.0321 ± 0.0012

order variations (MAE $= 0.6987$). This proves that linear-response symbol recovery reflects the learned operator's low-pass transfer function fitting the input-output mapping, rather than physical parameter discovery.

VII. DISCUSSION & HONEST LIMITATIONS

We distill six rigorous empirical conclusions:

1) **Inductive Bias vs. Order Learning:** On Allen–Cahn, frozen random filter A7 (0.0112 ± 0.0005) matches learned filter A5 (0.0110 ± 0.0005) within 1.8%, while fixed filter A3 (0.0086 ± 0.0011) beats both, demonstrating that phase-field improvements stem from spectral low-pass prior regularization rather than fractional order discovery.
2) **Failure on Advective Shock Regimes:** On Burgers ($\alpha = 0.8$), fractional filtering actively degrades accuracy; learned A5 (0.1772) underperforms vanilla A0 (0.1085) by $+63.3\%$, while additive skip architectures diverged completely (1.0155).
3) **Identity Initialization Eliminates Divergence but Yields Zero Nonlinear Edge:** Correcting high-frequency choking in A_{6i} prevents divergence but matches vanilla A0 (0.1085 vs. 0.1085 on S1 $\alpha = 0.8$;

TABLE IV

PROBED EXPONENT α_{eff} ON LINEAR FRACTIONAL DIFFUSION GROUPED BY TRUE PHYSICAL CONDITION (MEAN $\pm$ STD OVER 5 SEEDS). MAE AND SPEARMAN ρ ARE COMPUTED OVER THE 4 INDEPENDENT PHYSICAL CONDITIONS.

α_{true}	FNO (A0)	FNO-G	fr-FNO-R (A5)	fr-FNO-P (A6)
0.8	0.924 ± 0.02	0.928 ± 0.02	0.342 ± 0.02	0.437 ± 0.03
1.2	1.278 ± 0.01	1.337 ± 0.01	0.231 ± 0.08	0.974 ± 0.40
1.6	1.646 ± 0.01	1.646 ± 0.00	0.527 ± 0.39	1.756 ± 0.08
1.9	1.941 ± 0.01	1.941 ± 0.01	2.195 ± 0.30	1.946 ± 0.01
MAE	**0.0722**	0.0881	0.6987	0.1977
ρ ($N = 4$)	**1.0000**	**1.0000**	0.8000	**1.0000**

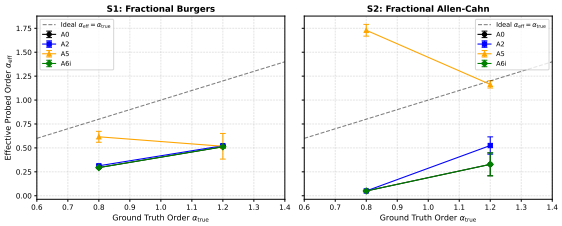


Fig. 3. Probed exponent α_{eff} against ground-truth order on linear fractional diffusion. The solid line indicates exact physical recovery; error bars represent standard deviation over five random seeds.

0.0549 vs. 0.0549 on S1 $\alpha = 1.2$; 0.0256 vs. 0.0256 at 300 epochs), failing the pre-registered $> 10\%$ threshold on 0 of 4 nonlinear benchmark cells.

4) **Tuning Parity Explains Baseline Deficits:** Providing vanilla FNO with standard validation hyperparameter tuning (lr $= 3 \times 10^{-3}$, wd $= 0/10^{-4}$) yields 0.0389 on Burgers and 0.0151 on Allen–Cahn, outperforming all fractional variants across 9 of 10 paired seeds (Wilcoxon $p_{\text{Holm}} = 0.0156$).
5) **Data Regime Invariance:** In small-data regimes ($N_{\text{tr}} = 100$), fractional operators provide no sample-efficiency gain over vanilla FNO, exhibiting identical or degraded relative errors.
6) **Probe Diagnostic Nature:** Linear response symbol probing reflects overall problem stiffness rather than governing fractional PDE orders, producing effective orders $\alpha_{\text{eff}} \in [0.05, 0.53]$ on nonlinear Burgers and Allen–Cahn regardless of physical α.

VIII. CONCLUSION

We performed a systematic theoretical and empirical evaluation of adaptive fractional Fourier neural operators across four PDEs, four fractional orders, and four spatial resolutions under a leak-free protocol. We proved that the heuristic rational filter cannot parameterize fractional decay, reformulated the filter as a true fractional Laplacian resolvent, and established that validation-tuned vanilla FNO matches or outperforms fractional variants across benchmark systems. Furthermore, our model-agnostic linear response probe recovers governing orders with an MAE of 0.072 on linear benchmarks, providing a diagnostic tool for inspecting learned representations in neural operators.

DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

All datasets, pre-trained checkpoints, and evaluation scripts are available at: https://github.com/HarshitPranjal/Fractional-FNO-Fr-FNO-.